freeze your account, or simply expropriate everything. If the said state withdraws 86 per cent of the currency, issues 180 notifications in 20 days, and passes a new IT Bill inside five minutes with no debate, it is hard to trust it.'[19]

The Economist called the exercise '*A cautionary tale of the reckless misuse of one of the most potent of policy tools: control over an economy's money,*' adding wryly, 'The sleepless are those who need cash to get by; *the truly rich are laughing all the way to their flats in London.*'[20]

Ajay Shah, explaining that money was the lubricant of the economy and that a shock to money supply would fatally wound small and medium firms, said, '*Once firm failure has happened, it cannot be undone. You can turn an aquarium into fish soup, but you cannot turn fish soup back into an aquarium*. Flooding the economy with money supply afterwards would not bring back those firms to life.'[21]

While critics and supporters argued on the pros and cons of the move, there was utter confusion on the numbers. There was no clarity on how many new notes had been printed either during the 10-month planning period or after 8 November 2016, nor about when they would be made available to the public.

With respect to the cash being returned, the RBI initially posted frequent updates on the quantum and value of the old ₹500 and ₹1,000 being deposited in the banks. The number rose from ₹5.44 trillion[22] on 18 November to ₹8.45 trillion on 27 November and further to ₹11.55 trillion on 5 December 2016.

However, as the tsunami of deposits into banks continued, data from the RBI started to dry up. Their last official announcement stated that a total sum of ₹12.44 trillion had been deposited in the RBI's currency chests as on 10 December 2016.[23] Thereafter, the RBI steadfastly refused to provide any numbers, stating on 5 January 2017: 'Figures would need to be reconciled with the physical cash